Campaign Face-off

How the key adversaries are framing the Tamil Nadu contest

	DMK+	AIADMK-BJP+
CORE NARRATIVE	Dravidian model, welfare delivery, state's rights, anti-Centre positioning	Governance reset, anti-incumbency, corruption charges against DMK
LEADERSHIP PROJECTION	M.K. Stalin as stable, experienced administrator	EPS as governance-focused leader; BJP's Modi factor
ORGANISATION MODEL	Grassroots network, data-backed mobilisation	Cadre revival; BJP's centralised campaign support
ADVERSARY POSITIONING	BJP as threat to federalism; AIADMK aligned with Centre	DMK as corrupt, dynastic and inefficient
MINORITY STRATEGY	Strong consolidation of Muslim and Christian voters	Careful balancing, focus on broader consolidation
WELFARE PROMISES	Expansion of welfare (cash transfers, free bus travel...)	Higher payouts, jobs push, price control narrative

Ramadoss Sr to put up joint candidates in some seats. The AIADMK also faces competition from newer political entrants. Actor Vijay's TVK is expected to draw some of the anti-incumbency votes that might otherwise have gravitated toward the AIADMK.

Taken together, the 2026 election presents the AIADMK with a layered challenge: an uneasy alliance with the BJP, partial mobilisation by allies and the emergence of the TVK as a new pole. While the party seeks to frame the contest as a straight fight with the DMK and has hard-focused on anti-incumbency and farmers' woes, the ground reality is that even small shifts in vote share across regions could significantly shape the outcome and determine the AIADMK's trajectory in the post-Jayalalithaa era.

The Known Unknown

When actor Vijay announced the formation of the TVK in February 2024, reactions ranged from curiosity to scepticism. Film stars entering politics is hardly new in Tamil Nadu. But two years on, the TVK has created enough buzz that the question now is less about whether the party matters and more about what kind of impact it will have on the DMK-AIADMK-dominated political landscape.

Like many other top Tamil film stars, Vijay has a structured fan base engaged in welfare activities and local mobilisation. But as other ill-fated star-neta runs have shown, such fan associations seldom translate into political capital. What distinguishes the TVK is the extent to which these networks appear to have been repurposed, participating in civic initiatives and electoral contests, and offering a tentative organisational starting point.

Vijay has positioned the TVK as an alternative to the Dravidian majors while also keeping some distance from the national parties. This will allow him to appeal to voters dissatisfied with the existing choices without being tied to any one bloc. His campaign style, however, largely centres on his own appeal. Many a time, the actor forgets to even mention the party candidate's name in the constituency, only urging voters to support him and the TVK's 'whistle' symbol.

This sort of messaging raises questions about how far the TVK's organisational depth extends beyond Vijay's popularity. Political scientist Ramu Manivannan frames this as a question of political grounding. "Good leaders come from the people and climb on to the bus," he argues, adding that "a man who's not even stepped out of the bus doesn't seem like a leader of the people".

The party's political messaging also does not signal an ideological rupture. The rhetoric on governance, social justice and welfare aligns closely with the broad framework that has defined Tamil Nadu politics for decades. Rather than challenge the established model, the TVK appears to be positioning itself as a new executor of familiar priorities. The party's support base also appears to draw from segments not tightly bound to existing party structures, including younger voters and those disillusioned with traditional choices.

For Vijay, the transition from cinematic icon to political leader represents a test of whether personal credibility can evolve into institutional authority. The early phases of TVK suggest an attempt to build that transition systematically. Sustaining the momentum, though, will require organisational consolidation, leadership development, and consistent political engagement.

At this stage, the TVK occupies a space between disruptor and contender. Whether it evolves into a durable third pole or remains a transitory force remains to be seen. But it has transformed the Tamil Nadu battle into a tripolar contest that makes it difficult for pollsters to predict the outcome. ■